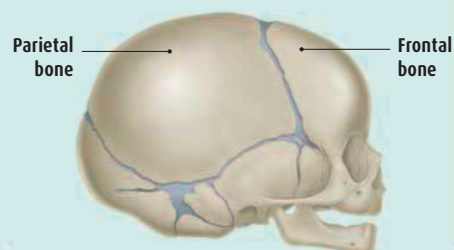


ARMS AND LEGS

"Limb buds" appear on the trunk of the embryo at around five weeks of pregnancy. Her limb buds extend so that by nine weeks, her arms and legs have grown in length. These are held in shape by the long bones that have formed within them. At 14 weeks gestation, your baby's arms will probably be long enough for her to bring her hands together in front of her face, but much of her skeletal structure is still cartilage. Her limb bones will ossify from the center outward, leaving the tips cartilaginous (and leaving room for growth) in childhood.

SKULL

The flat bones that make up the sides and top of your baby's skull skip the cartilage stage and ossify directly from the membrane that surrounds her brain. By 14 weeks, your baby has a nearly complete skull made up of the flat bones, the jaw, and the cartilage of the nose. The flat bones don't fuse properly, so that your baby's skull can mold to the shape of your pelvis during birth.



SPINAL COLUMN

This is the first part of your baby's skeleton to develop. At five weeks, a rudimentary spinal cord and structures called somites form down her back (see p.49). The vertebrae form when parts of the somites (sclerotomes), split in half to allow the nerves of the spinal cord to reach through them and attach to the emerging muscles. The skeletal muscles form from another portion of the somites (the myotomes) at around seven weeks; muscle groups form first at the spine, then extend to the torso and limbs.

